

Student Success Doesn't Live in One Department

Guests: Dr. Andrew Tomko, Vice President of Academic Affairs and Provost

Dr. Anthony (AJ) Trump, Vice President of Student Affairs

Institution: Bergen Community College

Host: Katy Oliveira, Civitas Learning

INTRODUCTION

Katy Oliveira 00:00

Today, we're diving into one of the most persistent hurdles in higher ed — the division between academic and student affairs. When these two divisions operate in silos, it's the student that often feels the disconnect. But on today's episode, we're joined by two leaders from Bergen Community College who have moved beyond simple coexistence to forge a truly collaborative partnership — one where data and shared insights serve as the bridge between the classroom and student support.

Joining us today is Dr. Andrew Tomko, Vice President of Academic Affairs and Provost. Dr. Tomko's journey began at Bergen in 1994 as a faculty member in the English department, and today he oversees all four academic divisions as well as the library and tutoring center. He is joined by his colleague and partner in this work, Dr. Anthony AJ Trump, Vice President of Student Affairs. Dr. Trump leads enrollment management, student services, and athletics, and is deeply committed to using technology-enabled strategies to ensure every student has the opportunity to belong and succeed.

Today we're discussing the pivot point that forced these two divisions to align, how to make data accessible to frontline staff without causing burnout, and how to root a collaborative spirit into a campus identity.

AJ Trump 01:52

Thank you. It's really nice to speak with you too.

Andrew Tomko 01:54

Thanks. Same here.

Katy Oliveira 01:56

For those who might not be familiar with you, can you tell us a little about yourselves and the work you're doing at Bergen Community College to impact student success? Andrew, do you want to start?

Andrew Tomko 02:08

Sure. I'm the Vice President for Academic Affairs at Bergen Community College. I've been in this role for two years now and at the college for over 30 years — as a faculty member in English and through a range of academic leadership roles. My goal is really to empower change at the college. Higher ed is going through a lot right now, and academics has traditionally moved

at a glacial pace — but we don't have that luxury anymore. We're facing real challenges with budgets and declining enrollments, and I'm doing my best to empower faculty to bring fresh ideas, look at curricula that have become stale, and give students the tools they need to succeed in today's workforce.

AJ Trump 03:30

Hi, I'm AJ Trump — not related. I'm the Vice President of Student Affairs at Bergen Community College. I've been here about four years and have over 20 years of experience in student affairs administration. At Bergen, our president and strategic plan have set a goal to increase retention and completion rates by 1% each year over the next five years. I'm trying to be very intentional about that — looking at our data, identifying what's actually moving the needle, maybe abandoning some things that aren't, and working very closely with Andrew, because the academic division has so much opportunity. A lot of times my division implements those changes and is responsible for ensuring their integrity.

Another area we work diligently on, as a community college, is student supports and basic needs. If a student is living out of their car, or hungry, it's more than just about the classes. We're constantly finding ways to assess and grow how we support students, meet them where they're at, and reduce hardships and disparities in student outcomes — regardless of their background.

FROM COEXISTENCE TO COLLABORATION

Katy Oliveira 05:31

What's really exciting about your work is how closely you work together and the relationship you've fostered — a unified, comprehensive approach. In many institutions, academic affairs and student affairs usually operate in silos. What was the specific pivot point or shared challenge that forced your two divisions to stop coexisting and start collaborating?

AJ Trump 06:26

I've worked at a couple of institutions and I've been through a number of vice presidents and leadership changes. I've found it works best when academic affairs and student affairs work together — I've seen what happens when it's siloed and it doesn't help students. So I made a commitment that when I got to this level, I was going to do everything I could to support my counterparts on the academic side.

When Andrew jumped into his role shortly after I started, his experience as a faculty member and chair at Bergen for so many years helped me be better at my job. He understood the culture, the history, why things were the way they were — but he also had this great ability to be forward-thinking. I quickly realized his vision was aligned with mine, and I said: we need to get our heads together and move this institution forward.

Andrew Tomko 07:43

AJ and I hit it off immediately. We had a lot of shared values and a shared commitment to student success. I've worked with more student services VPs than I can count, and I never had the kind of synergy I've found with AJ. He really understands academics — not just his own area, but the different demands and culture that academics has.

To your question, Katy — what was the moment? I think the incident that first really brought us together was addressing the mess that was scheduling at the college. Our course grid had grown organically over the years — not intentionally. We had a common 15-week schedule, then added a 12-week term, a late-start semester, and eventually two 7-week semesters. Of course none of those times lined up. Students would come to me saying, 'I want to take this math course, but it starts one minute before my English course ends.' AJ and I sat down, he quickly drew up a much more sensible grid, and we looked at it and said: how did we not do this for 30 years?

Then AJ helped me present data to faculty — here's what's happening, here are the causes, here's a much more sensible plan. That combination of data and credibility was what made it work.

GETTING BUY-IN AND NAVIGATING CULTURE CHANGE

Katy Oliveira 10:29

How do you get buy-in — especially on the faculty side? In environments where new can feel like more work, or where 'this is how we've always done it' is the default, how do you frame change? How do you minimize cultural friction without pretending it doesn't exist?

AJ Trump 11:49

Our faculty and staff are very unfiltered and honest — they'll tell us exactly how they're feeling. One of my mentors once told me: AJ, if you're not taking flack, you're not flying over the target. I take all of that feedback and talk it over with Andrew: these are real concerns, how should we address this?

Where I think it worked for us is Andrew's credibility. He's got 30 years as a faculty member. Some faculty came to us when we changed the schedule and said, 'This is sacred — the most important thing to a faculty member.' And while that surprised some people, Andrew and I knew that getting the schedule right is one of the biggest factors that impacts student success. Andrew put data in front of the faculty at a Faculty Senate meeting, and it made all the difference.

Andrew Tomko 13:53

And the answer is it's not easy. Faculty are very committed — but in some cases, really attached to the way things have been done for a very long time. They see themselves as part of a discipline that goes back to the Middle Ages, and there's something wonderful about that historical continuity. But it does take time to convince them that the old ways aren't always the best ways.

Hitting with data was really critical. But equally important was my credibility with faculty. When someone starts to say 'you don't...' in a Faculty Senate meeting, I can say, 'Hold on — I do. I've been here 30 years. I've been a faculty member, a chair, a coordinator, a dean. I've seen it from every perspective.' That empathy matters.

Beyond data and credibility, the combination is really listening. I made it a point to go to department meetings, have an open door, stop and chat with people in the hall. The only way to get real cultural shifts is to be patient and to really listen.

What also helps recently is that everyone understands how dramatic the higher ed situation is right now — budget cuts, grant reductions. What I've said repeatedly to faculty is: the only way you can put yourselves in jeopardy is by doing nothing. That's getting traction. You can't convince everybody — but what you can do is get a group of committed people on board, and they become your champions.

USING DATA TO DRIVE CHANGE

Katy Oliveira 17:51

I'm curious to hear more about the data you shared to compel faculty to move forward. And I know data can sometimes feel like surveillance or critique. How did you approach using evidence to make the case — and AJ, student success staff can also be resistant to this. How has data-driven change looked on that frontline staff side?

Andrew Tomko 18:53

The most recent example is the substantive changes we're making to developmental education. Faculty had a sense of purpose in standalone dev ed — a belief that students weren't quite ready for college-level work and needed protection first. But the data shows completion rates in standalone dev ed are abysmal. In some cases, under 30% of students who start in standalone dev ed ever make it to a college-level course. For some student demographics, it's in the single digits.

That kind of data is sobering. You can see it on people's faces. And the counterpoint I have to make is: I know you believe you're doing really good work, and in another universe maybe that would be true — but in the universe in which we live, these courses are actually preventing students from getting the degrees that will change their lives. Things like completion rates and success rates — faculty at our institution had not really been used to looking at them. And when you do, the numbers tell a very different story than the intuitive sense that you're doing a good job.

AJ Trump 22:29

For frontline staff, I start with our divisional meetings. I dedicate time every month to talk about data and what's going on. When we were going through the developmental ed and placement changes, I had people from our testing office present on the placement discrepancies — and how students of color were being disproportionately placed into developmental ed. That got the word out, and people in my division talk — it works its way through the institution.

You can't overwhelm people with a whole lot of data at once — you want to give little snippets that help move the initiatives you're working on forward. Andrew and I also hold a Monday leadership meeting where his deans and my leadership team get together to talk about hot issues, hot-button topics, and use that time as a working session: what is the data showing, what should we do, how do we make continuous improvement?

Another key point: national data has its place, but you really want to look at your own institutional data. How our institution is set up is very different from the 10 institutions that might inform a national survey. There's real power in looking at what your own data says about your own students.

SURPRISING FINDINGS FROM INSTITUTIONAL DATA

Katy Oliveira 26:36

I think the power of institutional data is that it can get you beyond national best practices. Sometimes those best practices are the low-hanging fruit — you put them in place, see some early gains, then stall. Have you found pockets where a small shift made a big impact in a surprising way?

AJ Trump 28:14

From the financial aid perspective, when I started we were seeing a lot of students approaching maximum timeframe — and we have a large English language learner population. That became an impetus for reducing standalone dev ed. Now in English we're down to one standalone developmental course that very few students are placing into; most are placing directly into college-level with a co-requisite support. Probably 50 to 60% of our students need financial aid to attend school. If they're running out of aid because they're stuck in dev ed, we're essentially stopping their education. These strategic reductions will take a year or two to show up in the data, but we know they're going to move the needle on completion and persistence.

Andrew Tomko 29:32

Math is a stumbling block for a lot of students. What we found was that students would wait until their last semester to take math because they're afraid of it — and then discover they'd placed into developmental math and needed two more semesters. So for a while, we required students to take math before completing 16 credits. Intuitively that seemed sound, but what was actually happening is students were failing earlier and getting frustrated and leaving earlier.

It forced us to address a more fundamental question: how much and what kind of math do non-STEM students really need? What does math literacy actually look like for a student going into the workforce — financial literacy, understanding interest rates? That's a different question than calculus. It's a multi-stage process. You've got an issue, you address it, you come up with a solution, and that solution generates a new problem. That's okay — as long as you don't think one solution will solve everything for another 10 years. It's continuous improvement. The only way to do that is to keep looking at data and keep questioning what you're doing.

AJ Trump 32:23

One more exciting finding: there's a national movement right now around micro-credentialing, and we looked at our data and found over 2,000 students in the past few years who had earned certificates but never applied for them — they transferred or left without claiming what they'd already achieved. Andrew and I and a team of academic and student affairs administrators sat down and said: we have to get those credentials into students' hands while they're still with us.

This isn't just about completion rates and funding formulas — though it helps there too. It's about students seeing their own progress and gaining the confidence to persist. A lot of students say 'I'm only here for two years and then I'm transferring.' If they earned a certificate along the way, let's award it to them. Encouraging students to persist when they see they're making progress is one of the most powerful things we can do.

WHAT STAYS BEHIND: LEGACY AND INSTITUTIONAL IDENTITY

Katy Oliveira 39:20

If you both move on to other opportunities in three years from now, what is one shift you hope is deeply rooted in your campus's identity?

AJ Trump 39:45

My hope is that I've done the work with my team so that the silos are broken for good — that with or without me, my team understands they cannot work in silos anymore. The work they do impacts their colleagues in other departments and other divisions and impacts the whole college. And the other thing I'd want to see is people really using data to drive change and not using exceptions to drive change — that when they see an exception, they look deeper before reacting with a big change.

Andrew Tomko 40:58

I'll keep it at one. I'd like my legacy to be that academics becomes a place known to be dynamic and change-ready — that the next person doesn't have to come in and convince people to move. That the system is already in motion. That people are constantly questioning, constantly ready to refresh, and looking at data to update all the time — without needing someone like me to come in and say 'you need to do this.'

Katy Oliveira 41:35

What you're saying is we've got to move from this old-fashioned higher ed model where everything is fixed and institutional, to one that is more nimble, dynamic, and collaborative — and can be more responsive to our rapidly evolving world.

Andrew Tomko 42:00

Absolutely.

CLOSING THOUGHTS

AJ Trump 42:17

The relationship between academic and student affairs is one of the most impactful relationships on a campus when it comes to enrollment, retention, and student success. If you're in student affairs and don't have great relationships with your academic counterparts, I encourage you: learn about the academic side of the house. Learn the processes, the procedures, the history and culture. Teach a class if you're able to. Talk to faculty members. When we only look at things from our own perspective, we miss a whole lot that's outside our view. When you know how other people function and what their priorities are, you can have a bigger impact on the institution.

Andrew Tomko 43:16

I'll echo that. Get your academics and your student services people to meet in small groups and work in committees — even just once a month, a brown bag lunch to share ideas. Have student services people teach. Have academic people do more advising, shadow a financial aid worker, see the stress students carry just trying to pay and navigate all the hoops. Getting that perspective — stepping outside your own world — is extremely, extremely valuable.

Katy Oliveira 44:09

This has been a really lovely conversation. Thank you both so much for coming on the podcast.

